

CONCLUSION

The Mongols established a heterogeneous world empire that connected the East with the West, Shamanism and Buddhism with Islam and Christianity, and a sedentary civilisation with a nomadic existence. Within this empire, a nomadic minority, based on strong armed forces, ruled over a multi-ethnic, multicultural and multilingual population for over a century. This study suggests that, among these subject populations, the Armenians provide an example of a people that were incorporated into the Mongol Empire by establishing a close relationship with the Mongols. The Mongols dealt with the Greater Armenians along with the Georgian monarchy as a subject people, and with the Cilician Armenians, as a vassal state and allies.

Greater Armenia's geographical location as a bridge between Asia and Europe attracted the Mongols, although only the pursuit of the fugitive Kh^wārazmian Shah brought the Mongols to Greater Armenia, which enabled the expansion of the Mongol Empire to Asia Minor. The Mongols first came across with the Greater Armenians, whose land was supervised by separate Armenian lords, the vassals of the Georgian King. The advance of the Mongols into the Caucasus and Armenia was implemented by the Mongol *noyans*, who divided the Armenian lands into lots among them, thus safeguarding not only their own mobility, but also resisting their opponents' consolidation.

However, the division was informal. The Armenian lords' policy of collaborating with Mongol *noyans* helped them to retain their occupied lands. Therefore, Mongol rule in Greater Armenia resulted in almost no change in the lifestyle of the Greater Armenians from 1236 to 1243.¹ *Yeke Monggol Ulus* (the Great Mongol State) built its administration in Armenia mainly using indirect rule and governing through local elites. This enabled the Armenian lords to preserve not only their lands, but also their local administration intact, although in order to prevent the resistance of their subjects and to pursue economic gain, the institution of Mongol governors, *darughachis*, co-existed in Armenia. This Mongol office was designed to deal

¹ Bedrosian, 1979:116.

with non-Mongols in non-Mongol lands and the Armenian sources confirm their function in Greater Armenia through their explicit references to the census, taxes and people who were in charge.

The impact of the Mongol financial and economic regime in Greater Armenia was certainly severe. However, in comparison with the destruction of China, Central Asia and Russia, caused by initial Mongol conquests, the Armenians' treatment looks far more merciful. This was due to the intelligence and policy of the Greater Armenian rulers, whose survival instinct led to their timely submissions.

The advance of the Mongols into Asia Minor brought them into contact with the Cilician Armenians, who voluntarily submitted to the Mongol Empire. The Cilician Armenian monarchs chose to ally with the new rising nomadic power against their hostile Muslim neighbours. The acceptance of Mongol suzerainty ensured Cilician Armenia's survival against the far more dangerous threat from the Mamluks. On the other hand, the Cilician Armenian ports on the shores of the Mediterranean Sea surely attracted the Mongols.² Therefore, entry into the Cilician trade zone contested by different powers would be exploited by the Mongols, who preferred to have the Cilician Armenians as their ally.

Thus, by 1256, going through the different patterns of submissions, one forced, the other one willingly, the Greater and Cilician Armenians came to the same result of being subjects of the Mongol Empire, paying tributes, taxes and being obliged to provide troops and labour. However, the Cilician Armenians did not experience the economic pressures from the Mongols as the Greater Armenians did.

When the Mongol conquest extended to the shores of the Mediterranean, having destroyed both the 'Abbasid Caliphate and its Ismā'īlī opponents, Hūlegū demanded fresh troops for his ongoing conquests. Since the Mongol army was not salaried and relied mainly on the acquisition of booty, a large-scale mobilisation of the subject population was necessary. The role of Cilician Armenian troops

² The commercial class of tradesmen in Cilicia allowed Cilician Armenia to participate actively in the international trade of the region. The Armenian ports contributed to the exchange of culture, science and art between eastern and western Asia, the study of which still awaits further exposition. Among the cultural exchanges during the Mongol conquest, the Armenian contribution has not been elaborated apart from the mentioning of personnel exchange of princes, clerics and merchants (Allsen, 2001:6). On the Muslim-Armenian-Mongol artistic interchanges, see Soucek, 1998:115–131.

exceeded that of just a military tribute. The Cilician monarchs assisted the Mongol plan to conquer Syria by appealing to them to liberate the Holy Land from the Muslims, which was consistent with Mongol imperial ideology and their own ambitions.

The mobilisation of human, military and material resources accelerated the interethnic engagement that resulted in creating far-reaching and extensive cross-cultural contacts. These contacts between the Mongols and Armenians were established from the beginning of their relations. According to the Armenian sources, the process of learning about each other was evident. The Armenians' initial assumption that the Mongols were the avengers of the Christians from the tyranny of the Muslims turned out to be false.³ In due course, the Mongol *noyans* learned about the Armenians through their immediate contacts with them, and the mutual understanding of each other's purposes resulted in timely individual and state submissions by the Armenians and in the establishment of a military alliance, which was mutually beneficial.

Hülegü and his Greater Armenian partner the Zak'arian prince Prósh, and the Cilician King Het'um I not only extended the Mongol conquest into the Middle East, but also acted as implementers and partners of the alliance which was conceived to liberate the Holy Land and eliminate the Muslim supremacies in the region.

The success of the Mongol-Armenian partnership was important for Armenians in both the Caucasus and Cilicia. Although for different causes and according to different patterns, the interests of the Greater and Cilician Armenians coincided over the issues of assisting the Mongols. The strategy of the Greater Armenian lords towards the Mongol presence was cooperative, rather than confrontational, regardless of several attempts to revolt. In fact, the collaboration of Awag Zak'arian through Chormaghan with Güyük Khan, Hasan Jalal through Sartakh with Möngke Khan, Smbat Orbelian with Möngke Khan and Hülegü, and Sadun Artsruni with Hülegü and Abaqa Khan paid significant dividends for both the Armenians and the Mongols. This alliance was supported by many other factors. One of the forms of the maintenance of good relations was the forging of diplomatic marriages between the Caucasian nobility and the Mongols.⁴ The

³ Kirakos Gandzakets'i, 1961:202.

⁴ Kirakos Gandzakets'i, 1961:263, 391.

sources mention several cases where the Mongols took Christian spouses.

Religion was a tool for the Mongols to implement their conquest. The Mongols' notion of world dominion is believed to have been built on their universalistic idea of being chosen by Heaven. This is especially interesting because this ideology was carried on by the descendants of Chinggis Khan even after the Mongol Empire disintegrated. The Mongols were aware that the religious questions could be an obstacle in their pursuit of conquests. Believing in only the eternal power of Heaven, they dealt with Christians and Muslims on a daily basis without any major persecutions motivated by the religion of their subjects. The Mongol governors understood that the Church in Armenia was an active part of society and that it played an important role in ensuring political and social stability within the country. Therefore, the clergy and nobles were freed from a number of obligations and from the necessity of paying some taxes.⁵ According to the statements of Armenian historians, the monks and lords of Greater Armenia were also employed by the Mongols as their diplomats and secretaries.⁶

This pragmatism extended also to treatment of the Muslims.⁷ Individual Muslims were posted to key positions, gaining promotion to a very high rank in the court of the Il-Khans.⁸ It is worth attesting that Muslim-Mongol collaboration contributed to the success of Hülegü as much as Christian-Mongol cooperation.⁹ Adjusting to the local tradition of conquered territories, the Mongols ruled Muslim subjects for several generations. The question of the sincerity of the Mongols' conversion to Islam is to some extent irrelevant. It could be interpreted as a tactical move in order to rule the subject majority, but whether sincere or not on a personal level, the fact remains that Islamisation did not greatly influence Chinggisid policy

⁵ Step'annos Orbelian, 1910:412.

⁶ Kirakos Gandzakets'i, 1961:243–252; Davit' Baghishets'i, 1956:346.

⁷ For the careers of Turks, Kh'arazmians and other people, see Rachewiltz, 1983:281–310; Endicott-West, 1989:65–88.

⁸ The representatives of both the old bureaucratic families, like the Juvaynīs, and the non-bureaucratic, like the Rashid al-Dīns, were ministers and governors in the Il-Khanid courts and they did their best to retain Iranian governmental traditions (Morgan, 1990:110).

⁹ Amitai-Preiss, 2004:35.

at the Mongol court in Iran.¹⁰ This ideological re-orientation was an action prompted by political and military considerations, with the aim of retaining power over the conquered lands. The role of the Mongols in using the hostility between the Christian and Muslim religions contributed to their policy to rule the world.

It is important to note that the Mongols did not change the ethnic composition of the Armenians, unlike previous or later incursions of Arabic and Turkic tribes and dynasties. The Mongols neither assimilated with the Armenians, nor were absorbed by them. The shift of Mongol power in Greater Armenia from individual Mongol commanders to the Chinggisids, who demanded the *noyans* move on to Asia Minor, and who established themselves in Iran, not in Armenia, precluded the assimilation process. As has been said above, the Il-Khans ruled Greater Armenia through their governors and kept their major armies in Mughan, Arran, Rūm and Azerbaijan. Moreover, the Mongols were in a minority, being more under the threat of absorption by local customs than their subjects were to Mongol assimilation. Another factor that contributed to the Armenians' resistance to nomadic culture was their sedentary civilisation. Yet, the Armenians contributed to the consolidation of the Mongol Empire. The role of joint Mongol-Armenian forces in overthrowing the Muslim supremacies was immense.

As has been said above, among the steppe tribesmen of the thirteenth century, the Mongols were the most successful in creating a world empire. The Mongol advance into Iran and then into the Caucasus was part of the Mongol conquest of the world. Among the Chinggisids, this was also a political action to provide the offspring of the Toluids with certain lands to rule. This practical move was a cause of warfare among the Chinggisids. The wars of the Il-Khans against the Golden Horde over the pastures in the Mughan plain and Azerbaijan took place in the territories of Georgia and Greater Armenia. However, Mongol-Armenian collaboration is attested to have existed during these wars, despite the devastations of these lands.

The constant wars with the other Chinggisids halted the Il-Khans' ambition to pursue further their imperial goals. The Mongol Il-Khans' advances on the Syrian coast, regardless of the unsuitability of the

¹⁰ On continuity and change in Ghazan's policy after 1295, see Allsen, 2001:31–34.

climate and environment, intensified the Mongol-Mamluk wars. In their fight against the Mamluks, the Armenians were their only steadfast ally. For the Armenian Kingdom of Cilicia, the alliance with the Mongols was a political move to safeguard the kingdom's autonomy. It was also the opportunity to fulfil their and the Crusaders' dreams to re-conquer Jerusalem. On this point, Cilician Armenia and the Mongols shared the same aim, which was exemplified by the conquest of Syria and Palestine. Moreover, the Latin powers were directly called upon to support the Mongol-Cilician Armenian alliance. However, in the eyes of the West, the Mongols were still viewed as the barbaric pagan hordes threatening Europe.¹¹ When the situation in the Holy Land grew more desperate, the possibility of a general alliance between the Mongols and the West was seriously considered.¹² The overall result of these affairs was that the Mamluks focused their anger on Cilician Armenia.

The hostile Mamluk attitude toward Cilician Armenia as a Mongol ally was a serious issue, in addition to the Mamluks' economic interest, which caused the Armenians to try to strengthen their ties with the Il-Khans. The Cilician Armenian position remained strong as long as the Mongols were strong in the region. The cooperation of Het'um I with Abaqa against Baybars, Lewon III with Arghun against Qalāwūn, and Het'um II with Ghazan against al-Ashraf are examples of the Mongol-Armenian partnership in practice. This partnership co-exists with a series of appeals by the Il-Khans, namely of Arghun and Öljeitu, to the Papacy and their correspondence with the Latin powers, including the kings of France and England, which remain exclusive examples of medieval diplomacy. This led to the establishment of an exceptional multi-functional relationship with different outcomes between the Mongols, Armenians, Mamluks and the Christian West.

During the reign of Ghazan Khan, the hopes of the Mongols and Cilician Armenians of receiving assistance from the Christian West and from the Pope against the Mamluks were dashed. There was no

¹¹ The devastation of Hungary in 1285 and of Poland in 1287, and the Mongol protectorates established in Rus', Bulgaria, Byzantium and Lithuania were a serious concern to the Papacy in making some decisions about the Mongol-Latin alliance (Jackson, 2005a:268–274).

¹² The role of the Mongols in crusading projects after 1291 has been documented by Het'um Patmich', the major source for Mongol-Latin relations (Het'um Patmich', 1988:iv).

serious attempt to re-establish the fading Mongol-Armenian cooperation under the next two Il-Khans. Discords within the Armenian Kingdom in Cilicia and the Il-Khanate, and the peace established between the Mongol Il-Khan Abū Saʿīd and the Mamluk Sultan al-Nās)ir Muḥammad b. Qalawūn, the events strongly linked to each other, ended the Mongol-Armenian partnership. In fact, the alliance held good for more than half a century and the Armenians showed loyalty to their Mongol counterparts. They played an essential role in the multi-ethnic society of the *Yeke Monggol Ulus*. This study has tried to show that the issues of the Mongol-Armenian partnership deserve to be studied in their own right and on their own terms.